



Properties that have been contaminated, or that are perceived to be contaminated, by commercial or industrial use create a blight on a community. Such sites may be hazardous to the health of the environment and nearby residents. Their presence and questionable status can cause declines in property value.

The EPA has long recognized the need to clean up such sites, and in 2002 Congress passed the **Small Business Liabilities Relief and Brownfields Revitalization Act**. The act's title is quite a mouthful, so it's commonly known as the Brownfields Law. **Brownfields** are abandoned or otherwise unused commercial or industrial sites, many of which are suspected to contain hazardous waste.

Contamination may be from a number of sources, including petroleum, industrial waste, and even methamphetamine labs. The Brownfields Law provides grant funds to communities in order to assess and clean up the many thousands of brownfields that are believed to exist nationally. Many states also have programs to help finance the environmental restoration and reuse of brownfield sites.